people ties, which is regarded as "the living bridge"—was under immense strain, with the Trump administration pushing new tough policies on H-1B visas, green cards and legal migration that created big hurdles for Indian IT professionals, academics and students.

The optics for the secretary of state's visit, therefore, were carefully choreographed. Rubio, along with his wife Jeanette, sweated his way through Kolkata, Delhi, Agra and Jaipur in the punishing summer heat, leading a foreign policy wonk to joke: "Earlier, it was said that only mad dogs and Englishmen wandered around in this heat. Now, Americans can be added to the list." To his credit, Rubio got the rhetoric right, praising India as an indispensable global partner and assuring Delhi that the US-Pakistan relationship was "tactical", not strategic. He underlined America's commitment to a strategic partnership, telling INDIA TODAY, "We deal with a lot of countries, but we have a handful of really important strategic alliances, and India is one of them. We have so many areas of overlap that we care about what India cares about, and that we both have capabilities to contribute, so it makes sense." (*See interview.*)

There was theatre of another kind, too. At the US embassy's celebration in the capital marking 250 years of American independence, where Grammy award winner A.R. Rahman was invited to belt out his hits, Gor pulled off the sort of political stagecraft that the Trump universe understands best. The ambassador got Trump on a cellphone, live, to say warm things about Prime Minister Narendra Modi and India. It was a neat encapsulation of the moment that was personalised, performative and pleasingly over the top. Trump's words helped the mood music. Rubio's visit supplied the diplomatic melody.

CONFLICTING SIGNALS

While the visit restored some warmth, it also underscored a larger reality: the tensions in Indo-US ties are structural. As Congress leader and foreign policy expert Shashi Tharoor wrote in a newspaper column, "A single successful visit cannot completely undo a year of systemic whiplash. While Rubio effectively managed the acute symptoms of the crumbling partnership, the underlying disease—the radical unpredictability of Washington's transactional MAGA foreign policy—remains uncured."

When it comes to geopolitics, the glue holding India and the US together is coming unstuck. The two countries were never allies in the formal sense, but both increasingly viewed Beijing's rise and assertiveness as a challenge to stability in the Indo-Pacific. Today, India is uncertain about where exactly Washington stands. The Trump administration has sent conflicting signals on China—at times confrontational,



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ON A LIGHTER NOTE Rubio speaks at an event in New Delhi, May 24

INTERVIEW MARCO RUBIO



'India & the US are entering an era of limitless opportunities'

On his first visit to India as US Secretary of State, Marco Rubio spoke to *India Today*'s Rohit Sharma. Excerpts:

ON RELATIONS WITH INDIA

We deal with a lot of countries, but we have a handful of really important strategic alliances, and India is one of them. There are so many areas of overlap that we care about what India cares about, and we both have capabilities to contribute, so it makes sense. We are here really just to continue to build upon that relationship, because in every new era, there are new opportunities and new challenges that emerge around the world, and India is one of the countries we work closest with on all of these.

ON THE US-INDIA TRADE DEAL

We all have a lot of reason to be optimistic that we're on the verge of a trade deal. It'll be a great thing because it'll be good for both countries. It will increase both US investment here and Indian investment in the United States. It'll create a platform for more co-investment and more cooperation between our companies. Obviously, you know, things like tariffs and all that sit on top of the broader relationship and affect all of it. The sooner we can put that to rest with a good trade deal that's good for both countries, the opportunities are limitless.